CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Thursday, November 12, 2026 No. 232 11 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Kim Jong Un inspected a major east coast naval base under construction, ordering completion on schedule.
2. FM Cho Hyun departs Friday for Beijing to discuss North Korea and bilateral ties with Wang Yi.
3. President Lee broke ground on Samsung's Chungcheong semiconductor packaging plant, projecting 23.6 trillion won in added investment.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,342.73	1,332.05	$92.30	41%	Today	3.00%
−0.6%	−0.7%	−0.5%	+2 pts Nov 3-5	public appearance	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

NK News, DPRK

Kim inspects east coast naval base, orders timely completion

Kim Jong Un inspected construction of a major naval base on North Korea's east coast on Nov. 11, ordering completion within the schedule and to the quality standard set by the party central, KCNA reported Nov. 12.

NK News analysis places the inspection site in Munchon, north of Wonsan, where base construction began over 12 years ago and satellite imagery showed work restarting in August 2026. Senior officials **Pak Jong Chon** and **Jo Yong Won** accompanied the inspection; NK News separately identified a second major east coast naval base project, indicating simultaneous expansion on both coasts.

Korea Times, China-Korea

FM Cho flies to Beijing Friday for Wang Yi talks on North Korea and bilateral ties

Cho Hyun will make a two-day visit to Beijing starting Friday to meet Chinese Foreign Minister **Wang Yi**, covering North Korea-related issues, bilateral relations and regional matters, Seoul's foreign ministry said Thursday. The visit follows Wang's August invitation during Seoul talks, where Cho urged Beijing to play a constructive role in bringing North Korea back to dialogue.

Reuters, ROK Economy

Lee says Samsung chip packaging expansion will spur $30 billion in additional investment

President **Lee Jae-myung** said Samsung Electronics' advanced semiconductor packaging fab expansion in Asan, South Chungcheong Province, would spur *$30 billion* in additional investment, Reuters reported Thursday. Lee attended the groundbreaking of three Chungcheong Mega Project anchor facilities, including a semiconductor advanced packaging fab in Asan, an advanced display production line, and an AI server high-performance substrate plant in Sejong, just four months after the project's announcement in July 2026. Six of eight anchor companies have begun active construction.

02 | OVERNIGHT

FT, US-Korea

Asia trade deal partners have delivered just 2.7% of pledged financing

Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan have made available only 2.7% of promised financing under investment pacts.

The Washington Post, US-Korea

South Korea's ambassador pens WaPo op-ed defending $350B US investment bet

The ROK ambassador makes the public case for Seoul's strategic rationale.

Euromaidan Press, ROK Politics

Seoul-Kyiv ministers meet without apology; $100M Ukraine budget earmark stands

FM Cho and Ukraine FM Sybiha held their first face-to-face meeting since Seoul recalled its ambassador in October; Seoul's 2027 budget earmarks $100M for Ukraine.

Hankyoreh, ROK Politics

Court administration chief calls Han Deok-su impeachment threat over detention 'inappropriate'

Court administrator said releasing Han on statutory detention expiry is unrelated to guilt.

Yonhap News Agency, US-Korea

Korean American Congressman-elect Dan Koh expresses concern over US-Korea alliance under Trump

Koh said Trump "shows more admiration and respect" for North Korea than South Korea.

Hankook Ilbo, ROK Politics

Special prosecutor raids National Election Commission over alleged security-audit document forgery

Twenty-five investigators executed search and seizure at NEC servers and two contractor offices.

Asia Economy, ROK Economy

Industry minister pledges tighter government oversight of Czech nuclear project amid contractor change

Minister Kim Jung-gwan chaired a Team Korea Czech nuclear project progress review, pledging no disruption as the construction contractor is replaced.

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

23.6조원

Additional investment projected from Chungcheong Mega Project groundbreaking

President Lee Jae-myung attended the Chungcheong Mega Project groundbreaking on Nov. 12, with 6 of 8 anchor firms beginning active construction; the project total is cited as 392 trillion won.

Edaily / korea.kr, Nov 12 2026

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

Public appearance: Kim Jong Un inspected the construction site of a major naval base on North Korea's east coast, ordering that it be completed on the schedule and to the quality standard set by the party central.

No KCNA watch flag. 5 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

> *"Modern naval base construction is a major core project directly linked to our state's safety and defense of maritime sovereignty, and must unconditionally be completed within the period decided by the party central and at the quality level demanded by the party central."*
>
> **Kim Jong Un**, N. Korea's Kim inspects east coast naval base under construction, urges timely completion

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Yonhap / KCNA, DPRK state media

North Korea warns of action against US-led naval buildup

KCNA carried a statement warning that North Korea would take action against the US-led naval buildup in the region, coinciding with the east coast naval base inspection.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Choe Son-hui, Foreign Minister, DPRK

Choe released a commentary via KCNA rejecting the G7 joint denuclearization statement and affirming North Korea's nuclear buildup as steadfast.

Pak Jong Chon, Vice Chairman, WPK Central Military Commission

Pak accompanied Kim Jong Un's inspection of the east coast naval base construction site on Nov. 11.

Jo Yong Won, WPK Secretary

Jo Yong Won accompanied Kim Jong Un's east coast naval base inspection on Nov. 11.

> **Bottom line:** State media led with Kim's east coast naval base inspection and DPRK FM rejection of G7 denuclearization; all recent weapons tests remain absent from domestic KCNA output.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Thursday, November 12, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Director-General Lee Gyu-ho

MOFA hosts 9th MOFA-Civil Society Policy Dialogue on development cooperation

The 9th MOFA-Civil Society Policy Dialogue convened Nov. 12 under Development Cooperation Bureau Director-General Lee Gyu-ho, with 10 civil society representatives, KOICA, and KCOC; the meeting discussed the ROK's grant aid vision and a Humanitarian-Development-Peace (HDP) Nexus strategy.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

Presidential spokesperson Kang Yu-jeong

Blue House denies report that President Lee opposed Yoon Suk Yeol impeachment

Presidential spokesperson Kang Yu-jeong issued a written statement calling a media report that President Lee Jae-myung had opposed former President Yoon Suk Yeol's impeachment, attributed to Democratic Party senior committee member Choi Min-hee, "completely groundless" and expressing "strong regret."

Newsis

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Lee Yong-cheol NOMINATED

Minister of Justice

Lee Yong-cheol, former head of the Defense Acquisition Program Administration described as a 'bulldozer,' was nominated as Minister of Justice; PPP opposition lawmakers said he would be unqualified unless he pledged that President Lee Jae-myung's indictment would never be dropped.

06 US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so no baseline reciprocal tariff now applies. Section 301 investigations launched in March 2026 against South Korea and 15 other partners are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B US energy purchases; no official Strategic Investment Corporation drawdown figure reported to date.

07 CAPITOL HILL

Asia Economy, Statement

South Korea's US investment could be delayed as Democrats take control of Congress

An expert assessment warns that Democratic control of the House could slow legislative support for the ROK-US $350B investment pledge and related cooperation frameworks, as Democrats have signaled skepticism toward deals struck under the Trump administration.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Yonhap, China-Korea

North Korean embassy in Beijing renovated as Pyongyang-Beijing exchanges intensify

The renovation coincides with the June Kim-Xi summit pledge to elevate bilateral ties and the opening of the New Yalu River Bridge in mid-October.

State Dept, China-Korea

Rubio and Wang Yi discuss Trump APEC trip and Xi's G20 visit to Florida

Secretary of State **Marco Rubio** spoke with Director of the Office of the CCP Central Foreign Affairs Commission and Foreign Minister **Wang Yi** at China's request, covering Trump's upcoming APEC travel to China and Xi Jinping's visit to Florida for the G20; they reaffirmed a bilateral commitment to strategic stability on the basis of respect, fairness, and reciprocity.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Reuters, Southeast Asia, Diplomacy

President Lee to visit Philippines and attend APEC summit in China next week

President Lee Jae-myung will visit the Philippines for ASEAN-related summits before attending the APEC summit in Shenzhen, China on Nov. 18-19; a presidential official said the possibility of North Korea attending APEC or any US-DPRK contact on the sidelines was low.

Korea JoongAng Daily, Southeast Asia, Defense exports

Korea and Indonesia seek joint arms exports beyond troubled KF-21 partnership

Seoul and Jakarta are exploring joint arms export opportunities beyond the contested KF-21 cost-sharing dispute, with both sides seeking new frameworks for defense industrial cooperation.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Korea Economic Daily

KOSPI trading volume down 60% in six months as AI-driven retail frenzy fades

Daily trading value on the Korea Composite Stock Price Index (KOSPI) fell from 65 trillion won in May to around 20 trillion won this month, with the stock turnover rate at a 16-year low as doubts mount over the AI-driven rally.

Hankook Ilbo

Government cuts public redevelopment service fee from 3% to 1% to accelerate housing supply

The Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport and Korea Land and Housing Corporation will temporarily reduce the public redevelopment service fee from 3% to 1% of total project cost through December 31 2027, cutting per-project costs by an average of approximately 13 billion won.

Korea Land and Housing Corporation

korea.kr, Primary

Chungcheong Mega Project breaks ground; 8 anchor firms accelerate investment

Six of eight anchor firms in the Chungcheong Mega Project began active construction on Nov. 12, four months after the project's July announcement; the full project value is cited at 392 trillion won.

Samsung Electronics

Daily NK

State grain stores undercut North Korean jangmadang rice prices, complicating market gauges

In 2026, state-run grain stores are selling rice at prices that sometimes undercut private markets, eroding the decades-old reliability of jangmadang rice prices as North Korea's key economic indicator.

11 UPCOMING

NOV 13

FM Cho-Wang Yi talks, Beijing

Foreign Minister Cho Hyun holds talks with Chinese FM Wang Yi on North Korea and bilateral relations, with a dinner the same day.

NOV 16

President Lee departs for ASEAN, APEC summits

President Lee Jae-myung departs Nov. 16 for the ASEAN+3 summit in Manila, Philippines, then the APEC summit in Shenzhen, China on Nov. 18-19, where he is scheduled to attend Xi Jinping's welcome dinner.

NOV 19

Supreme Court en banc hearing on Han Deok-su

The Supreme Court holds a second full bench hearing on the Han Deok-su insurrection case on Nov. 19, one day before his maximum statutory detention of six months expires on Nov. 20.

NOV 20

Han Deok-su detention expires

Former Prime Minister Han Deok-su's maximum Supreme Court-level detention of six months expires Nov. 20; the special prosecutor warned his release could disrupt ongoing trial proceedings.

12 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 11

"On the sidelines of the G7 Foreign Ministers' Meeting, I met with Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha. I emphasized that mutual respect, trust, and faithful implementation of agreements are basic preconditions for the relationship to develop, and I expressed hope that all pending issues would be resolved smoothly. Sybiha proposed continuing diplomatic efforts to keep relations stable. We also exchanged views in depth on developments on the Korean Peninsula and in Ukraine."

The meeting was the ministers' first face-to-face since Seoul recalled its ambassador in October over the North Korean prisoner disclosure dispute; Korea's 2027 budget earmarks $100M for Ukraine. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

STATEMENTS

Lee Jae-myung

"What matters is action and execution."

Lee attended alongside Samsung Electronics Chairman Lee Jae-yong at the groundbreaking for the Asan semiconductor advanced packaging fab, four months after the project's July 2026 announcement. **Source**

COMMENTARY

The Choe Hyon, North Korean Navy Surface Ship, and Its Strategic Implications. 38 North's analysis examines the Choe Hyon destroyer, its cruise missile capabilities, and its strategic implications for the West Sea Fleet. It provides context for the simultaneously reported construction of a second east coast naval base. (Joshua NT Park, 38 North)

From Yard to Fleet: How South Korea Can Strengthen US Shipbuilding. The IISS K-Defence podcast episode examines what South Korea can offer the US in shipbuilding amid maritime competition with China. It addresses obstacles limiting greater cooperation and how the two allies might divide labor for a more resilient maritime industrial base. The piece is directly relevant as the $350B pledge's $150B MASGA shipbuilding component remains under discussion. (Dr Lami Kim, Dr Jonathan Caverley, The International Institute for Strategic Studies)

Taking Stock of the U.S.-Korea Alliance | The Capital Cable #146. CSIS's Capital Cable episode assesses the current state of the US-Korea alliance. It addresses the domestic political context in both Washington and Seoul affecting alliance management. The piece is timely given Democratic gains in the US midterms and ongoing uncertainty around the Trump administration's approach to the alliance and North Korea diplomacy. (CSIS)

13 PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

41%

+2 pts vs Oct 27-29
Gallup Korea
November 3-5, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 8 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
36%	**28%**	**28%**

14 THE WIRE

DPRK

NK News

Seoul sees slim chance of Trump-Kim contact at APEC

A senior ROK presidential official said North Korea's attendance at a multilateral event was unlikely, and that the overall chance of any contact, including before or after APEC, was low, while declining to rule it out entirely.

NK News

Defense minister: North Korea closing conventional gap via drone technology

Defense Minister **Kang Shin-chul** told the National Assembly budget committee that the ROK retains the upper hand in conventional forces but North Korea is closing the gap in science and technology, citing drone flows from the Ukraine war; Seoul is seeking about 80 billion won ($58 million) for an integrated counter-drone system.

Korea Times

DPRK FM rejects G7 denuclearization call, vows steadfast nuclear buildup

North Korean Foreign Minister **Choe Son-hui** released a commentary condemning the G7 joint statement from the Paris foreign ministers' meeting, saying North Korea's commitment to nuclear buildup remains "steadfast" and rejecting UN Security Council resolutions banning its weapons programs.

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NK News

Ex-Ukrainian official: large-scale North Korean troop redeploy to Russia unlikely this winter

Former head of Ukraine's Center for Countering Disinformation **Andrii Kovalenko** assessed that another large-scale North Korean troop deployment to Russia this winter was unlikely, despite recent warnings from President Zelensky of a planned dispatch.

US-KOREA

Yonhap

Seoul expands Cheonghae anti-piracy unit's operational scope toward Arabian Sea

The defense ministry submitted a revised motion to the National Assembly expanding the Cheonghae Unit's operational zone from off Somalia to south of Oman in the Arabian Sea, placing it under the "tactical control" of an on-scene commander from the US-led Combined Maritime Forces or the EU in a "very restricted" manner.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

38 North satellite imagery from October 16 confirms trucks traversing the New Yalu River (DPRK-Friendship) Bridge one day after the October 15 official opening, marking the start of commercial vehicle traffic. Daily NK reports (Oct 31) that North Korean trucks have still not joined Chinese cargo trucks on the bridge two weeks after the Oct 15 opening; North Korean transport officials are still preparing vehicles. North Korea-China trade reached $299M in September 2026, the second-highest monthly total in 2026. Kim Jong Un crossed the New Yalu River Bridge on October 24 during his unannounced visit to Dandong. Daily NK reports on Nov 3, 2026 that North Korea is courting Chinese investors to build hotels and shopping complexes in Sinuiju. NK News reports a surge in North Korean delegations visiting China, putting commercial ties in focus. Daily NK reports Nov 12 that Chinese truck drivers who relied on side income ferrying parcels across the new bridge are souring on operations due to tighter customs checks and movement controls since the October opening.

imagery as of 2026-11-12

10 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 232

TOMORROW

FM Cho-Wang Yi talks, Beijing

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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